

flowers or the band or photography (maybe even the cake) and just opting for a very nice dinner with friends and family to celebrate. The most important part of the big day, in her opinion, is always who shows up, especially in families where the brides' or grooms' sexualities may be contentious subjects.

My other theory about the increase in spending for gay weddings is that there are simply more of them now. In these trying Vice President Pence times, members of the LGBT community want to get married more often to ensure certain protections. A lot of McCowen's recent clients want to be married for the legal benefits and protections. Those filing a joint tax return can get deductions and also get access to the other person's retirement money, something that eluded queer couples for decades. Legally, there's the next-of-kin benefit if a partner is sick or disabled or in the hospital: you can now make decisions on their behalf and visit them. You can also sue for wrongful death and make decisions regarding your dead spouse's burial.

LGBTQ and HIV activist Cleve Jones told Terry Gross in his 2016 episode of NPR's *Fresh Air* that he (and the rest of the world) realized the importance of marriage to LGBTQ people during the AIDS crisis in the 1980s and 1990s. Many people who'd been with their partners for decades suddenly had no rights when their partners got sick. The sick partners were unable to be added to their partner's health insurance in order to get the medication (cocktail) they needed. They were not allowed to visit each other whenever they wanted in the hospital. When the sick partner died, his long-term boyfriend had no legal rights when the family came in and, as Jones put, sold the house and kicked him out. LGBTQ marriage in the 1980s and 1990s became about much more than romance or parties. "Suddenly that little piece of paper meant, you know, the difference between actual life and death," Jones told Gross.

This is dark to think about when a marriage is just starting, but for me, it's the most convincing reason for getting married.

As of this writing, I am 29 years old, and I have a new girlfriend. We're not yet talking about marriage, though I have committed her to having six dogs sometime in the future. (Queer women know how to prioritize in relationships.)

Just in case, I looked it up, and in Los Angeles, it costs \$91 to go to city hall and get married. That money is for the public marriage license fee. I'll probably